2 Peasant, Tribal and other Movements

Introduction

The British gradually established their rule in India through successive conquests and economic control, which triggered widespread discontent. Resistance emerged from various sections of society—peasants, artisans, tribals, rulers, soldiers, and religious leaders—each striving to protect their own interests. Historian Bipan Chandra identifies three main forms of this resistance: civil rebellions, tribal uprisings, and peasant movements.

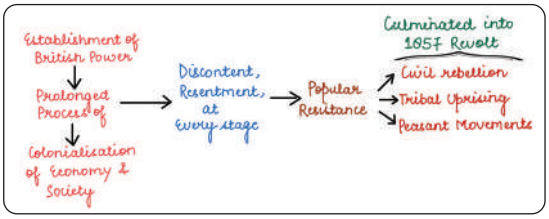

Fig. 2.1: Causes of Uprising
Diagram Type: *Input Process Output*

Civil Uprisings

The civil uprising included sections of society that were impacted by the British. Peasants, artisans, tribes, ruling classes, military personnel, religious leaders, etc. all engaged in conflict to protect their respective interests.

General Characteristics of Civil Uprisings

- **Traditional protest:** The semi-feudal leaders of civil uprisings were backward looking and traditional in outlook.
- **Aim to establish traditional customs**: Their basic objective was to restore earlier forms of rule and social relations. **For instance, Sanyasi Revolt**
- **Centred at the Local Level:** These uprisings were the result of local causes and grievances and were also localised in their consequences. e.g. Poligar revolt in south india
- **Affected traditional sections of society**: At a time when the newly created class of urban intelligentsia was reaping the benefits of British rule, it was the traditional sections of society, whose lives had been almost completely changed for the worse, who rebelled.

Major Factors Responsible for the People's Resentment and Uprisings against the Company's Rule

Causes of Civil Uprising

- **Economic Exploitation:**
  - **Loss to Peasants and Zamindars:** British land revenue systems and economic changes hurt peasants and zamindars, leading to suffering and discontent.
  - **Eviction and Exploitation:** Peasants faced eviction and exploitation by revenue collectors, tenants, and moneylenders, fueling resentment.
  - **Destruction of Handicraft Industry:** British promotion of manufactured goods and heavy duties destroyed Indian industries, causing unemployment and poverty.
  - **Transition to Agriculture and Pressure on Land:** Destruction of industries forced people into agriculture, increasing pressure on land.

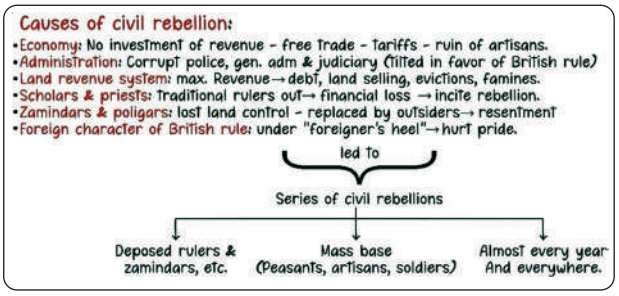

Fig. 2.2: Causes of Civil Rebellion

Social and Cultural Discontent:

- **Impact on Priestly Class:** British policies disrupted the social order, impacting the priestly class who protested against interference.
- **Encroachment on Tribal Land:** Expansion of revenue administration into tribal territories threatened their way of life, leading to resistance.
- **Personal Factors and Cultural Disdain:** British arrogance and disregard for Indian culture alienated rulers and the populace, fueling resentment.

Peasants Revolt

- A peasant revolt is a rebellion or uprising by farmers or agricultural laborers (peasants) against bright authorities, landlords, due to oppression, heavy taxation, exploitation, or poor living conditions.
- They eroded the power of the landed class, thus adding to the transformation of the agrarian structure.
- The peasants suffered from high rents, illegal levies, arbitrary evictions and unpaid labour in Zamindari areas. In Ryotwari areas, the Government itself levied heavy land revenue.

- The exploitation of natural and human resources by the British led to the rise of popular resistance movements, mainly by **Peasants, Tribals and Sainiks.**
- The simmering discontent of the peasants and tribal people broke out into popular uprisings in different parts of India at different points in time in the first hundred years of British rule.

Peasant Movements – Causes, Significance and Limitations

Causes:

- **Burdensome Land Revenue System:** The British land revenue systems, such as Zamidari, mahalwari and ryotwari land revenue system, were oppressive and often inflexible. Coupled with unpredictable weather and low crop prices, these policies severely impacted peasants' livelihoods. (**Example: Deccan Riots**)
- **Fluctuating Cash Crop Demands:** The rise and fall in demand for cash crops like **cotton (e.g., Indigo Revolt)** created instability for peasants. While a surge in demand might bring temporary benefits, it often led to exploitation by planters and traders.
- **Predatory Moneylenders:** Moneylenders collaborated with the British to exploit peasants through high-interest loans, further deepening their economic hardship. (**Example: narkelberia uprising**)

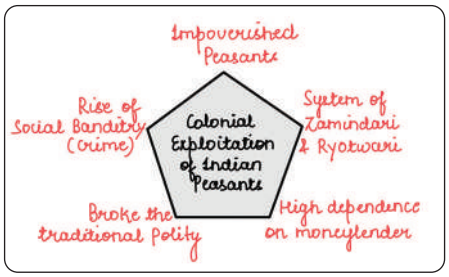

Fig. 2.3: Colonial Exploitation of Indian Peasants
Diagram Type: *Hub & Spoke*

- **Limited Scope:** These movements targeted specific grievances and local oppressors, including foreign planters, zamindars, and moneylenders. They lacked a broader vision to dismantle the entire colonial system. (**Examples: Bardoli Satyagraha, Indigo Revolt**)
- **Redressal of Immediate Problems:** Peasant movements sought immediate solutions to specific problems, like unfair revenue assessments or exploitative labor practices. They focused on achieving short-term goals rather than long-term systemic change. (**Examples: Bardoli Satyagraha, Indigo Revolt**)
- **Limited Organization and Reach:** These movements were often localized and lacked central organization. They primarily focused on specific regions or communities, hindering their overall impact. This also meant there was less continuity in their struggles.

Significance

- **Launching pad for future movements**: Peasant causes served as catalysts for subsequent movements like the 1857 insurrection as soldiers were peasants in uniform.
- **Legal Awareness**: Peasant movements offered insights into rights and how to legally oppose oppressors. This sparked widespread anti-colonial sentiment.
- **Complement National Movement**: Both the national and peasant revolutions thrived off of one another. The peasants served as a large-scale support base for the freedom struggle, while nationalism and Gandhi's Satyagraha philosophy spread to the villages, leading to more organised and peaceful peasant uprisings.
- **Transformed rural power structure**: In rural areas, peasant movements changed the balance of power by undermining the landed class's influence. **For example,** The Hyderabad feudal government was overthrown by the Telangana movement, which was led by peasants.
- **Post-Independence reforms**: Even though peasant protests were not immediately fruitful, they influenced post-independence changes that led to the abolition of zamindari and the guarantee of tenancy for tenants.

Limitations

- **Lack of innovative approach:** The 19th-century peasants did not possess a new ideology and a new social, economic and political programme.
- **Societal hurdle**: These struggles, however militant, occurred within the framework of the old societal order lacking a positive conception of an alternative society.
- **Localized spread**: Most of the 19th-century peasant movements were localised in specific regions. For instance, **The Deccan revolt** was in Maharashtra.
- **Colonial understanding**: There was a lack of an adequate understanding of colonialism. They did not target colonialism but instead focused on grievances redressal.

Changed Nature of Peasant Movements Post 1857

- **Main streaming of Peasants**: Peasants emerged as the main force in agrarian movements, fighting directly for their own demands.
- **Objectives:** The demands were centred almost wholly on economic issues.
- **Against immediate enemies:** The movements were directed against the immediate enemies of the peasant foreign planters and indigenous zamindars and moneylenders.
- **Not against colonialism and subordination:** Colonialism was not the target of these movements. It was not the objective of these movements to end the system of subordination or exploitation of the peasants.
- **Limited territorial extent**: Territorial reach was limited. There was no continuity of struggle or long-term organization.

- **Awareness of Legal Rights:** The peasants developed a strong awareness of their legal rights and asserted them outside the courts.

Comparison between 19th & 20th Century Peasant Movements

Features	19th Century Peasant Movements	20th Century Peasant Movements
Objective	The movement was almost entirely focused on economic matters, instead of putting an end to the exploitation of the peasants.	The struggle against colonialism started with Champaran, Kheda, and later Bardoli movements.
Leadership	Leaders emerged from the peasants themselves.	The movements were led by the Congress and the Communist Party. **Ex, Kheda Satyagraha led by Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel**
Spread of Movements	Limited Territorial spread **Ex.** Pabna Revolt in Bengal	All India Movements, **Ex.** All India Kisan Sabha
Colonialism Issues	Not target Colonialism grievances redressal, focus on local grievances	Emergence of anti-colonialism consciousness among peasants
Formal Organisation	There was as such no formal organisation at the national level	All India Kisan Sabha - established by Sahjahanad Saraswati.

Contribution of Social Reformers towards the Peasant Movement

- **Mahatma Jotirao Phule:**
  - He decided to create an awakening among the farmers and travelled on foot through many villages and went from place to place.
  - He went to the **Junnar and actively participated**.
  - He wrote a book entitled '**cultivators whipcord'** in which he narrated the sorrows of the cultivators.
  - The **weekly journal 'Deenbandhu'** highlighted the problems of the peasants.
  - He addressed the **sorrows of the peasants to the Duke of Connaught** when he visited Pune in 1888.
- **Vitthal Ramji Shinde and Peasants' Problem:**
  - In 1928, Shinde stepped out to prevent the catastrophe of the **Small Holding Bill.**
  - He emphasized that the corrupt officials, employees, and moneylenders had robbed the farmers of their land.
- **Pandurang Sadashiv Sane:**
  - Sane Guruji, also known as Pandurang Sadashiv Sane, was a key figure in the peasant movement.
  - He took a tour of the area and pressed for the land tax exemption.
  - He also put a lot of effort into the Faizpur Congress session.
- **Dr B. R. Ambedkar and Peasant Movement:**
  - His effective campaign against **Mahar Vatan** freed a sizable portion of the rural poor from a state of virtual serfdom.
  - He was successful in his fight against the prevalent Khoti system of land tenure, and he aimed to free the vast majority of people.
  - Furthermore, he spearheaded the **Chirner Satyagraha** of peasants.
  - Dr Ambedkar founded the "**Independent Labour Party**" as a political organization to combat the problems including farmers, migrant labour, and textile workers **on August 15, 1936.**

Indian National Congress (INC) and Peasant Movements

- **Prioritise peasant issues from the beginning:** It addressed the issue of Indian peasants from the beginning of the moderate phase. Extremist leaders also brought up the concerns of the rural class.
- **Faizpur session 1937 and Kisan Manifesto**
  - A significant number of resolutions for the benefit of the peasants were approved during the Faizpur session.
  - The meeting urged that the recovery of agricultural loans be postponed.
  - Additionally, it stipulated that landless labourers get an adequate minimum salary.
  - Reduction of land tax and rents by 50%
  - Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru, the session's president, invited workers and peasants to take part in congress activities.
- **Peasant movement as a pressure group:** The growth of peasant movements exerted considerable pressure on the Indian National Congress. Despite this, the Karachi Congress Charter did not even touch the fringe of the peasant problem. However, the political pressure of the Kisan Sabha succeeded in the Faizpur Congress agrarian program.

Tribal Revolt

A tribal uprising is a rebellion or resistance movement led by indigenous tribal communities against external authorities such as british government, local rulers, or landlords—due to exploitation, loss of land, cultural oppression, or threats to

their traditional way of life. Tribal uprisings in some parts of the Indian subcontinent dramatically increased in frequency and severity under British control. The **Kol rebellion, Santhal revolt, and Munda uprising** occurred in the 19th century.

Significance

- **Beginning of settled agriculture:** With the influx of non-tribal people into the traditional lands of the tribes, settled agriculture was created.
- **Started working as labour**: The British forced the tribal people to work as mineworkers and other menial labour since they had destroyed their traditional economic framework.
- **Importance to natural resources:** Tribal didn't like how the British exploited the earth's resources for their own material advancement.

Various Aspects of Tribal Uprisings

- **Northeastern frontier tribal revolts:** These uprisings occurred in the northeastern region and often aimed for autonomy within India. **Examples: The Santal Rebellion (1855) in Bengal and Bihar** exemplifies a **mainland tribal revolt** triggered by changes in land ownership customs.
- **Mainland Tribal Revolts:** Addressed issues of **land ownership** and exploitation by outsiders. **Example:** The Santhal Rebellion was a response to British attempts to impose taxes and **seize tribal lands**.
- **Northeastern Frontier Tribes:** Sought **independence** or **autonomy** within the Indian Union, merging with the national movement over time. **Example:** The Naga Rebellion sought independence for the Naga people in northeastern India.

Nature of tribal Revolt

- **Colonial Disruptions:** Displacement and resentment due to British policies disrupted traditional tribal relationships with **forests**.**Example:** The Munda Rebellion arose from displacement caused by British **forest policies**.
- **Oppression and Forced Labor:** Militant movements arose in response to **oppression** and **forced labor** imposed by the British. **Example:** The Khasi and Jaintia tribes revolted against British taxes and **forced labor** in coal mines.
- **Tribal Identity and Resistance:** Driven by a strong sense of **ethnic identity** and resistance to colonial encroachment. **Example:** The Bhil Rebellion asserted Bhil **autonomy** against British land encroachments.
- **Selective Violence:** Revolts targeted **colonial authorities** and collaborators while sparing sympathetic locals. **Example:** The Munda Rebellion selectively targeted British **officials** and settlers, sparing sympathetic villagers.

Factors Responsible for Tribal Movements (UPSC 2023)

- **Protest against the encroachment of the British:** The tribes were not pleased with the British gaining power in their own sphere of influence. They revolted and united against the government to protest the use of natural resources.
- **Biased act passed by the authority:** The Indian Forest Act of 1878 and the Government Forest Act of 1865, granted the government complete jurisdiction over tribal area.
- **Missionaries' activities:** The efforts of Christian missionaries, which the tribes detested, also caused social upheaval.
- **Oppressive approach of Moneylenders:** Moneylenders took advantage of the disadvantaged and ignorant tribal members. The British government provided security to the moneylenders.
- **Lack of understanding of colonial power**: Unlike Indian rulers, the British were unable to fully understand the tribes' commitment to their original habitat.

Limitations of Tribal Revolt

The early tribal movements had several drawbacks, even if they helped to develop an atmosphere that encouraged the voicing of local protest against authority. There were the following limitations of Tribal Revolt-

- **Localised and Isolated Spread**: They were localized and isolated events from a national standpoint that failed to grab the popular imagination of the country as a whole. This reduced the potential impact of these revolutions.
- **Sparked on local issues:** Additionally, the majority of these revolutions were sparked by local problems, and the rest of the country was unable to empathise with those who were protesting or connected with their plight.
- **Lack of Ideology**: The uprisings were merely outward demonstrations of protests over specific grievances; they did not involve revolutionary ideas, thoughts, or ideology.
- **Absence of Alternative approach:** They did not provide the people with an alternative solution or inspire them to take action. Most of these revolutions had semi-feudal leaders who, as a result, held traditional, conservative views.
- **Lack of bargaining skill**: So long as the British made even small concessions or acceded to their specific requests, they might be easily satisfied.

Difference between Tribal Movement and Mainstream Liberation Movement

The earliest phase of the tribal uprisings, however, was distinct from the mainstream liberation movement in the following ways:

- **Distinct Grievances**: Unlike nationalists, tribal people sought to reclaim customary authority over their land and traditions. They had no aspirations for the nation to become independent.
- **Use of Violence**: The tribes turned to the use of traditional weaponry and violence to further their goals, in contrast to mainstream nationalist leaders who advocated peaceful criticism.

- **Local organizational structures**: In the early years, the tribes organized their own military, collected taxes, and banded together based on kinship ties, and the educated middle class provided little support.
- **Lack of intellectual support**: The targets of tribal people were the local officials and moneylenders who had driven them from their land, in contrast to the goals of the Nationalists.

The oppressive and cruel actions of the British administration and moneylenders were repelled with resolute resistance by the tribes. Even though they were unable to end British rule, their actions encouraged their fellow citizens to stand together and oppose British practices. The Ramoshi, Bhill, and Koli initiatives in the Indian freedom war were instrumental in achieving independence in 1947.

Tribal Movements: Period, Region, Causes at a Glance

No.	Movement Name	Year and Place	Description
1	Pahariyas' Rebellion	1778; Raj Mahal Hills	Revolt by the martial Pahariyas against British expansion into their lands.
2	Chuar Uprisings	1776; Bengal region	Uprising by Chuar aboriginal tribesmen due to rising economic distress and British demands.
3	Kol Uprising	1831; Chottanagpur	Led by Buddho Bhagat; against British land policies and transfer of lands to outsiders.
4	Ho and Munda Uprisings	1827, 1831, 1899–1900, 1860–1920; Singhbhum, Chottanagpur, south of Ranchi	Revolts against British land occupation, revenue policies, and feudal exploitation; notable leader: Birsa Munda.
5	Santhal Rebellion	1855–56; Bihar	Led by Sidhu and Kanhu; against exploitation by zamindars and moneylenders; later turned anti-British.
6	Kondh Uprisings	1837–56 and 1914; from Tamil Nadu to Bengal, mainly Orissa	Led by Chakra Bisnoi; against British interference in customs and new taxes.
7	Naikada Movement	1860s; Madhya Pradesh and Gujarat	Revolt against British rule and caste Hindu domination.
8	Kharwar Rebellion	1870s; Bihar	Revolt against British revenue settlement activities.
9	Khonda Dora Campaign	1900; Dabur region, Visakhapatnam	Led by Korra Mallaya; campaign by Khonda Doras against British.
10	Bhil Revolts	1817–19 and 1913; Western Ghats	Against Company rule (1817–19) and for establishing Bhil Raj (1913).
11	Bhuyan and Juang Rebellions	1867–68 and 1891–93; Kheonjhar, Orissa	Led by Ratna Nayak and Dharni Dhar Nayak; against British-imposed rulers after death of local raja.
12	Koya Revolts	1879–80 and 1886; Eastern Godavari, Andhra Pradesh	Led by Tomma Sora and Raja Anantayyar; against police oppression and forest rights denial.
13	Bastar Revolt	1910; Jagdalpur	Against feudal demands and new forest levies.
14	Tana Bhagat Movement	1914–15; Chottanagpur	Led by Jatra Bhagat and Balram Bhagat; against outsider interference; started as Sanskritisation movement.
15	Rampa Revolts	1916, 1922–24; Rampa region, Andhra Pradesh	Led by Alluri Sitarama Raju; against British interference; Raju was executed in 1924.
16	Jharkhand Uprising	1920 onwards; Bihar, Orissa, West Bengal	Revolt for tribal identity and autonomy; led to formation of Adivasi Mahasabha (1938) and Jharkhand Party (1949).
17	Forest Satyagrahas	1920s, 1930s; Guntur (Andhra), Palamau (Bihar)	By Chenchus and Karwars; against British control over forest areas.
18	Gond Uprising	1940s	Movement to unite followers of Gonddharma faith.

North-East Frontier Tribal Movements: Year, Region, Major Causes Movements Before 1857

1. **Ahoms' Revolt (1828-33; Assam);** against the non-fulfilment of the pledges of the Company after the Burmese War; the uprising was suppressed by the Company by dividing the kingdom.
2. **Khasis' Revolt** (1830s; hilly region between Jaintia and Garo Hills); led by the Nunklow ruler, Tirath Singh; against the occupation of the hilly region.
3. **Singphos' Rebellion (**1829-33; Assam); led to murder of British political agent of Assam by Singphos in 1839; was ultimately suppressed.

Movements After 1857

1. **Kukis' Revolt (1917-19; Manipur)** against British policies of recruiting labour during the first World War.
2. **Revolts in Tripura** against hike in house tax rates and against settlement of outsiders in the region (a) led by Parikshit Jamatia (1863) (b) the Reangs' revolt led by Ratnamani (1942-43) (c) led by Bharti Singh (1920s)
3. **Zeliangrong Movement (1920s; Manipur)** led by the Zemi, Liangmei and Rongmei tribes; against the failure of the British to protect them during the Kuki violence in 1917-19.
4. **Naga movement (1905-31; Manipur)** led by Jadonang; against British rule and for setting up a Naga raj.
5. **Heraka Cult (1930s; Manipur)** led by Gaidinliu, the movement was suppressed but the Kabui Naga Association was formed in 1946.
6. Other Smaller Movements were the revolt of the Syntengs of Jaintia Hills in 1860-62, the Phulaguri peasants' rebellion in 1861, the revolt of the Saflas in 1872-73; the uprising of the Kacha Nagas of Cachhar in 1882; and a women's war in Manipur in 1904.

Military Uprisings in India (UPSC 2019)

These uprisings, fueled by discontent among soldiers, political issues, and social factors, were crucial precursors to the 1857 Rebellion. They sowed the seeds for a wider revolt against British rule.

Causes

- **Unequal Treatment:** Sepoys faced lower pay and fewer promotions compared to British soldiers.
- **Mistreatment:** Sepoys endured harsh treatment from British officials.
- **Foreign Service:** The government denied extra pay for deployments outside India.
- **Religious Concerns:** The General Service Enlistment Act (1856) clashed with Hindu sepoys' beliefs.
- **Shared Grievances:** Sepoys sympathized with civilian struggles against British rule.
- **Religious Conflicts:** Service requirements, like replacing turbans with hats (Vellore Mutiny, 1806), clashed with religious practices.

Major Sepoy Mutinies

Before the Indian Rebellion of 1857, several significant mutinies occurred:

- **Bengal Sepoy Mutiny (1764)**: A mutiny among sepoys in Bengal, indicating early signs of discontent within the ranks.
- **Vellore Mutiny (1806)**: Sepoys in Vellore protested against interference in their social and religious practices, raising the flag of the ruler of Mysore in revolt.
- **Mutiny of the 47th Native Infantry (1824)**: A rebellion by sepoys of the 47th Native Infantry unit.
- **Grenadier Company Revolt (1825)** by the Grenadier Company in Assam.
- **Sholapur Mutiny (1838)** by an Indian regiment in Sholapur.
- **Mutinies of the 34th N.I., 22nd N.I., 66th N.I., and 37th N.I.(Native Infantry)** (1844, 1849, 1850, 1852 respectively) were the various mutinies in different native infantry units.

While these mutinies were significant, they were localised and were brutally suppressed by the British Indian government. This involved violent measures, including executing leaders and disbanding the rebellious regiments. Despite their limited scope, these mutinies played a crucial role in shaping the larger rebellion that would occur in 1857.

Key Words

Economic Exploitation, Cultural Disdain, Handicraft Industry Decline, Land Revenue Systems, Sanyasi Revolt, Deccan Riots, Indigo Revolt, Pabna Rebellion, Bardoli Satyagraha, Ryotwari System, Predatory Moneylending, Zamindari Abolition, Social and Cultural Discontent, Impact on Tribal Lands, Nationalist Movements, Legal Awareness in Peasants, Rural Power Structure.

	Previous Year Questions	Year
1.	How did the colonial rule affect the tribals in India and what was the tribal response to the colonial oppression?	2023
2.	The 1857 Uprising was the culmination of the recurrent big and small local rebellions that had occurred in the preceding hundred years of British rule. Elucidate.	2019